

Erving Goffman (1922-1982) popularized a particular type of interactionist method known as the dramaturgical approach, in which people see as theatrical performers. The dramaturgists compares every day life to the setting of the theater and stage. Just as actors project certain images, all of us seek to present particular features of our personalities while we hide other qualities. Eg. In a class, we may feel the need to project a serious image, but at a party, we want to look relaxed and friendly.

Sociologist Goffman presented the idea that a person is like an actor on a stage. Calling his theory dramaturgy, he believed that we use "impression management" to present ourselves to others as we hope to be perceived. His best known contribution to social theory is the study of symbolic interaction. This took the form of dramaturgical analysis, beginning with his book "Presentation of Self in Everyday Life" (1956). His major areas of study included the

- 1) Sociology of everyday life
- 2) Social interaction
- 3) The social construction of self
- 4) Social organization of experience.
- 5) Particular elements of social life such as total institution & Stigmas.

He was a sociologist, who analysed social interaction, explaining that people live their lives much like actors performing on a stage. Dramaturgical analysis is the idea that people's day-to-day lives can be understood as resembling performers in action on a theater stage. As we present ourselves in various situations, we ^{are} much like actors putting on performances for their audience. Our life, according to Goffman, is a series of performance. Goffman argued that we put on different performances based on who our audience is.

The presentation of self is a person's efforts to create specific impression in the mind of others. This process, sometimes called impression management, begins with the performances we carry out each day. Our performances might include a) the way we dress (our costume)
b) the objects we carry w use (our props)
c) our tone of voice and gestures.

We might also vary our performances based on where we are (the set/stage). Most people would act differently in church than a restaurant. People also design their own homes and offices to bring about a desired impression w reaction in others.

Dramaturgy is a sociological perspective on identity that employs a theater metaphor to explore issues of identity formation & reformation. As such, dramaturgy assumes a place, a moment and an audience to whom the identity formation both in a social context (such as classroom, a family etc) as well as at a particular point in time. This implies that identities can shift with varying contexts & moments.

The key aspect to dramaturgy, however, is the concept of audience and an individual's relationship with that audience in that specific time & place. As with impressions management, the individual actor must control their presentation of self so as to evoke from this audience a desired reaction to that presentation. eg. Dinner Party where you act as a host and your friends as guest. It is natural that as a host you should provide all the foods & entertainment facilities to your friends.

A key element of dramaturgy is the concept of the Front & Back stage. In face-to-face interactions, the front - and back stage are two related but separate areas, where the front is the space in which the performance of self takes place and the back is where that performance is prepared.

Eg. For a waiter, the Front stage is the restaurant floor, where the waiter performs their identity as waiter for the diners. The back stage is the kitchen ~~for the diners~~ where that identity is relaxed until another order is up. As the waiter passes through the kitchen doors, they become the waiters once more, playing their 'assigned role' (Goffman 1997)

Dramaturgy acknowledges that identities are pluralistic - we have many identities that we put on and off as we move through time & space, and enter and exit different social contexts. As such, to achieve those goals, one has to be able to quickly switch and negotiate roles, or performative marks, as they move between different social contexts.

Impression management is a conscious or subconscious process in which people attempt to influence the perceptions of other people about a person, object or event by regulating & controlling information in social interaction.

Impression management is usually used synonymously with self-presentation in which a person tries to influence the perception of their image. The notion of impression management was first applied to face-to-face communication, but then was expanded to apply to computer-mediated communication, this concept is applicable to academic fields of study such as psychology & sociology as well as practical fields such as corporate communication & media.

Goffman coined the term impression management to refer to our desire to manipulate others' impressions of us on the front stage. According to Goffman, we use various mechanisms, called sign vehicles, to present ourselves to others. The most commonly employed sign vehicles are social setting - It is the physical place where interaction occurs. It would be Doctor's chamber, Principal's Room or someone's home. How we decorate our setting or what "props" we use, also gives clues to how we want people to think of us.

Appearance : Our appearance also speaks volumes about us. People's first impression are based almost exclusively on appearance.

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